

January

17

Sawn in half

British magician PT Selbit became the first person to perform the illusion of sawing someone in half. His assistant Betty Barker survived the trick at his London show to the relief of the audience.

1921



Born this day

1964 Michelle Obama, Black American lawyer and writer. She became the first Black woman to serve as the USA's first lady when her husband Barack Obama became the country's president.

1987

Caught on camera

The coelacanth was filmed for the first time in the Indian Ocean off the east coast of Africa. This rare bony fish had been discovered in 1938.



1893

Hawaiian queen

A US coup forced Queen Liliuokalani of Hawaii, its final monarch, to step down. Hawaii later became the 50th state of the USA. The US government has since apologized for its part in the coup.



Also on this day

1920 The 18th Amendment of the US Constitution banned the sale of alcohol in the USA. It was only repealed 13 years later.

1991 After Iraqi troops invaded Kuwait, the Gulf War began with bombing raids against Iraq by a US-led alliance of nations.

1997 Norwegian explorer Børge Ousland became the first person to make a solo crossing of Antarctica on foot. It had taken him 64 days.